PES UNIVERSITY

(Established Under Karnataka Act No. 16 of 2013)

100ft Ring Road, BSK 3rd Stage,

Bangalore-560085

“THE ROLE OF TONE IN WRITING CUSTOMER SERVICE RESPONSES.”

MBA PROGRAM

RESEARCH-BASED PROJECT

COURSE TITLE: CORPORATE COMMUNICATION
COURSE CODE: UM25MB621
SUBMITTED BY: PRAJWAL SV (PES1PG25MB173)
MBA TRIMESTER-I - “E SECTION”
SUBMITTED TO: PROF. SANJEEV NAIR
PES UNIVERSITY

The Role of Tone in Writing Customer Service Responses.

ABSTRACT

In today's business world, customer service interactions happen more often through written channels, like emails, live chats, and social media. Without vocal and non-verbal cues, the tone of written customer service responses becomes a key factor in customer satisfaction, trust, and service recovery success. A poorly framed tone can increase dissatisfaction and conflict, while a suitable tone can create empathy, reassurance, and lasting customer relationships.

This research looks at the role of tone in writing customer service responses and examines how different tonal approaches affect customer views and service results. The study uses a mixed research method, combining information from peer-reviewed journals with primary data gathered through an online survey. This primary data includes responses from 72 participants, representing various age groups, genders, and job backgrounds. The survey measured the perceived importance of tone, preferred tonal qualities, and the impact of tone on customer satisfaction and trust.

Results from the primary data show that most respondents view tone as a vital part of customer service communication, with empathetic, professional, and clear tones ranking as the most desirable. Respondents mentioned that an inappropriate tone, like overly robotic, dismissive, or too humorous responses, often leads to misunderstandings and negative customer experiences. The analysis also shows that empathetic and respectful tones work particularly well in handling complaints and service recovery.

The study concludes that there isn't a single correct tone for customer service responses. Instead, how effective a tone is relying on contextual factors, including the issue's nature, the communication method, and customer expectations. The research highlights the need for organizations to adopt tone-aware communication strategies and train customer service staff, thus improving customer satisfaction, trust, and overall brand image.

Keywords: *Customer Service Communication, Tone of Voice, Empathy in Communication, Service Recovery, Customer Satisfaction, Trust Building, Corporate Communication.*

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INTRODUCTION

In an era of rapid digital change, customer service has transformed significantly. It has shifted from face-to-face and voice interactions to mostly written communication channels like emails, live chats, chatbots, and social media. Today, organizations rely heavily on written responses to address questions, resolve complaints, and maintain relationships with customers across different locations. While technology has improved the speed and accessibility of customer support, it has also created new challenges. Most notably, there is a lack of non-verbal cues such as facial expressions, gestures, and vocal tone. In this situation, the tone of written customer service responses has become a key factor in shaping customer perception and experience.

Tone in written communication refers to the feelings, emotional undertone, and level of empathy expressed through words, sentence structure, and style. Unlike spoken communication, where tone can change through voice changes and body language, written communication relies fully on word choices to relay intent and emotion. A poorly chosen tone may come across as cold, dismissive, robotic, or uncaring, even when the message is factually correct. On the other hand, a well-chosen tone, characterized by empathy, politeness, clarity, and professionalism, can reassure customers, calm conflicts, and build trust. Thus, tone has become a vital part of corporate communication and customer relationship management.

The importance of tone is especially clear in customer service situations involving complaints, service failures, or dissatisfaction. Research in service recovery shows that customers evaluate not only the resolution provided but also the way the response is communicated. An apology given with empathy can lessen negative feelings, while the same apology delivered in a stiff or impersonal way may worsen dissatisfaction. In stressful service situations, customers often seek emotional recognition along with practical solutions. This underscores the dual purpose of customer service communication: solving practical problems while also managing customer feelings.

With the rise of automated customer service systems, such as AI-driven chatbots and templated email replies, concerns about tone consistency and emotional suitability have become more important. While automation boosts efficiency and scalability, it can lead to responses that

customers find mechanical or emotionally distant. Studies show that customers are more willing to trust and engage with organizations that use a “human” tone, even in digital communication. This has sparked an interest in tone-aware communication frameworks that balance efficiency with emotional understanding.

Despite the growing acknowledgment of tone as an important factor in customer service communication, many organizations still focus more on speed and uniformity than on sensitivity to tone. Customer service representatives often receive training focused on procedural accuracy and policy compliance, with little attention given to tone and emotional framing. As a result, even well-meaning responses may fall short of customer expectations, leading to escalations, negative word-of-mouth, and damage to brand reputation. In competitive service environments where customer loyalty is weak and alternatives are easy to find, poor communication tone can harm organizational performance.

From an academic perspective, research on tone in customer service communication spans various fields, including corporate communication, marketing, psychology, and information systems. Previous studies have looked at how empathy, politeness, formality, and conversational style influence customer satisfaction and trust. More recent research has focused on AI-mediated communication and how tone affects perceptions of reliability, sincerity, and connection. However, much of the existing research remains disjointed, often examining specific contexts like crisis communication, social media interactions, or chatbot responses. There is a need for unified research that looks at tone as a whole within written customer service responses across different settings.

This study aims to fill this gap by exploring the role of tone in writing customer service responses and its effect on customer satisfaction, trust, and service recovery. The research uses a mixed approach, combining insights from existing literature with primary data gathered through a structured survey. This data captures customer views on the significance of tone, preferred tonal qualities, and the consequences of using an inappropriate tone in service interactions. By including real customer opinions, the study moves beyond theoretical assumptions to provide practical, evidence-based insights.

The importance of this research lies in its practical value and relevance to management. As organizations increasingly communicate with customers through written digital channels, it becomes vital to understand how tone shapes customer perceptions. The study's findings can help organizations create tone-aware customer service guidelines, training programs, and communication templates that improve customer satisfaction and trust. Additionally, this research contributes to the academic discussion on corporate communication by highlighting tone as a key element of customer service interactions.

In conclusion, as customer service continues to change in digital settings, tone in written communication is no longer just a soft skill; it is a strategic necessity. Organizations that effectively understand and manage tone are better positioned to build strong customer relationships, handle service failures constructively, and maintain a positive brand image. This research aims to deepen the understanding of tone in customer service responses and provide actionable insights for both scholars and practitioners in corporate communication.

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LITERATURE REVIEW

The role of tone in written communication has received more attention from scholars due to the rapid growth of digital customer service platforms. As organizations move toward email, live chat, social media, and AI-powered customer support, researchers have pointed out that tone acts as a substitute for non-verbal cues in written interactions. Literature shows that tone greatly affects customer satisfaction, trust, and service recovery outcomes, especially during complaints.

Yin et al. (2017) conducted a key study on tone in customer service communication by creating a tone analysis framework specifically for online customer service chats. Their research showed that traditional sentiment analysis does not capture the subtle emotional cues in customer-agent interactions. The study identified various service-specific tones, such as politeness, empathy, frustration, and reassurance. It concluded that responses that are aware of tone lead to better customer engagement and satisfaction. This work established tone as complex rather than just a simple positive or negative sentiment.

Building on this, Hu et al. (2018) looked at the effectiveness of tone-aware chatbots in customer care. Their study found that empathetic and polite tones significantly reduced customer frustration and improved emotional recovery during service interactions. The authors noted that customers often judge the emotional quality of responses more critically than the technical accuracy of solutions. This underscores the need for a human-like tone, even in automated systems.

Liu et al. (2018) focused on analyzing customer feedback based on tone. They found that tone is a reliable indicator of customer experience quality. Their research suggested that organizations could use tone analysis to evaluate agent performance and find communication gaps. The results highlighted that customer dissatisfaction often comes from perceived emotional neglect rather than unresolved service issues, stressing the strategic role of tone.

Service recovery research has also highlighted the importance of tone, especially in apologies and responses to failures. Yeh et al. (2025) studied how tone interacts with recovery strategies in AI-generated customer service responses. Their findings revealed that formal and empathetic

tones improved perceptions of reliability and trust. In contrast, mismatches between tone and recovery strategies led to skepticism and negative emotions. This research showed that the effectiveness of tone varies by context and must match the nature of the service failure.

De Keyzer et al. (2017) analyzed the effects of emotional versus factual tone in online word-of-mouth communication. Their findings showed that emotional tone can be effective in relational contexts but may hurt credibility in high-risk or practical service situations. This suggests that while empathy is important, too much emotionality can backfire depending on the service context.

Barcelos et al. (2017) explored brand tone on social media. They found that a conversational human voice enhances customer engagement, especially for hedonic brands. However, in high-risk or complaint-heavy situations, customers preferred more professional and composed tones. This study suggests that tone selection should fit the context and customer expectations.

From a linguistic standpoint, Delin (2005) studied brand tone as a stylistic and discursive construct. She argued that tone reflects organizational identity and values.

Prasad (2020) researched professional email communication and stressed the importance of clarity, politeness, and a soft tone in business emails. The study concluded that tone directly impacts the perceived professionalism of an organization and plays a key role in maintaining long-term business relationships.

In crisis communication, Stewart (2025) examined how tone of voice affects brand trust and message acceptance. The findings indicated that corporate and personal tones worked better than humorous tones in crisis-related communications. While humor can engage in informal contexts, it was inappropriate in serious service recovery situations.

Overall, the reviewed literature shows that tone is a vital factor in how customers perceive written service communication. While empathetic and professional tones generally produce positive results, no single tone works for every situation. The suitability of tone depends on factors such as the severity of service failure, the communication channel, and customer expectations. This study builds upon existing research by integrating these insights with primary data to further explore customer perceptions of tone in written customer service responses.

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OBJECTIVES AND RATIONALE:

1) To Analyze the role of tone in written customer service responses and its influence on customer perceptions,

This objective aims to analyze how the tone used in written customer service responses shapes customer perceptions regarding professionalism, empathy, and overall service quality. As digital communication lacks non-verbal cues, customers rely heavily on tone to interpret intent and emotional sensitivity. By analyzing different tonal approaches—such as empathetic, neutral, formal, or informal—the study seeks to understand how tone contributes to customer satisfaction, trust, and acceptance of service responses

2) To Determine the key factors that influence customer preferences toward tone in customer service communication,

This objective focuses on determining the factors that affect how customers perceive and prefer specific tones in customer service interactions. These factors may include the nature of the customer issue, previous service experiences, communication channels, and customer expectations. Understanding these influencing factors helps explain why certain tones are more effective in specific contexts, particularly during complaint handling and service recovery. Identifying these factors enables organizations to tailor their communication strategies to align with customer expectations and improve the effectiveness of written responses.

3) To Evaluate and compare the effectiveness of different tones used in written customer service responses,

This objective seeks to evaluate and compare how various tones—such as empathetic, professional, neutral, or humorous—perform in influencing customer satisfaction, trust, and perceived service quality. By comparing customer responses to different tonal styles, the study aims to identify which tones are most appropriate in specific service situations. This evaluation provides practical insights for organizations to design tone-aware response frameworks and training programs, ensuring that customer service communication is both emotionally intelligent and contextually appropriate.

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RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

1. **Research Design**

   The present study adopts a descriptive research design with a primary focus on understanding customer perceptions regarding the role of tone in written customer service responses. A descriptive approach is suitable for this research as it aims to systematically describe and analyze attitudes, preferences, and perceptions of customers toward different tones used in customer service communication, rather than establishing causal relationships.

2. **Nature of the Study**

   The study is empirical in nature and is primarily based on primary data, supported by secondary literature for theoretical grounding. The empirical approach enables the researcher to gather first-hand information directly from respondents, thereby enhancing the relevance and reliability of the findings.

3. **Source of Data**

   a. **Primary Data:**

      Primary data was collected through a structured survey questionnaire administered online. The questionnaire was designed to capture respondents' perceptions of tone in customer service communication, preferred tonal qualities, and the impact of tone on satisfaction, trust, and service recovery.

   b. **Secondary Data:**

      Secondary data was sourced from peer-reviewed journals, conference papers, academic articles, and published research related to customer service communication, tone of voice, empathy, and service recovery. These sources provided conceptual support and helped frame the study objectives.

4. **Data Collection Method**

The primary data was collected using an online survey method, which allowed respondents to participate conveniently and anonymously. The survey consisted of closed-ended questions using multiple-choice options and Likert-scale statements to measure attitudes and perceptions related to tone in customer service responses. Online data collection was chosen due to its efficiency, wider reach, and suitability for gathering customer perception data.

5. **Sampling Method and Sample Size**

The study employed a convenience sampling method, wherein respondents were selected based on accessibility and willingness to participate. This method was appropriate given the exploratory nature of the study and time constraints.

The total sample size consists of 72 respondents, representing diverse demographic backgrounds, including different age groups, genders, and occupational categories. This diversity helps provide a broader understanding of customer perspectives toward tone in customer service communication.

6. **Scope of the Study**

The scope of the study is limited to examining customer perceptions of tone in written customer service responses, particularly across digital communication channels such as email and online support. The study focuses on how tone influences customer satisfaction, trust, and service recovery effectiveness and does not include face-to-face or voice-based customer service interactions.

7. Tools and Techniques of Data Analysis

The collected data was analyzed using simple statistical tools, appropriate for descriptive research. These include:

a. Percentage analysis
b. Frequency distribution
c. Mean score analysis
d. Graphical representation using bar charts and pie charts

These tools were used to interpret respondent preferences and perceptions in a clear and understandable manner.

8. Limitations of the Study

a. The study is based on a limited sample size of 72 respondents, which may restrict the generalizability of the findings.
b. The use of convenience sampling may introduce respondent bias.
c. The study relies on self-reported perceptions, which may be influenced by personal experiences and subjective judgment.
d. The research is confined to written customer service communication and does not consider verbal or face-to-face interactions.

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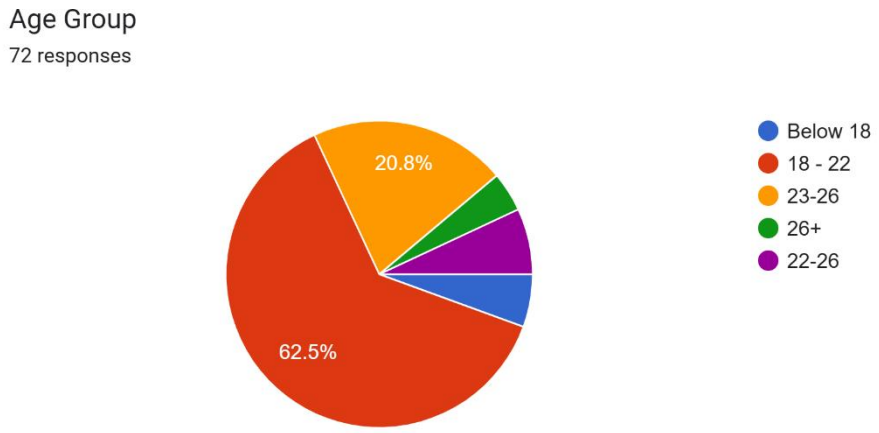
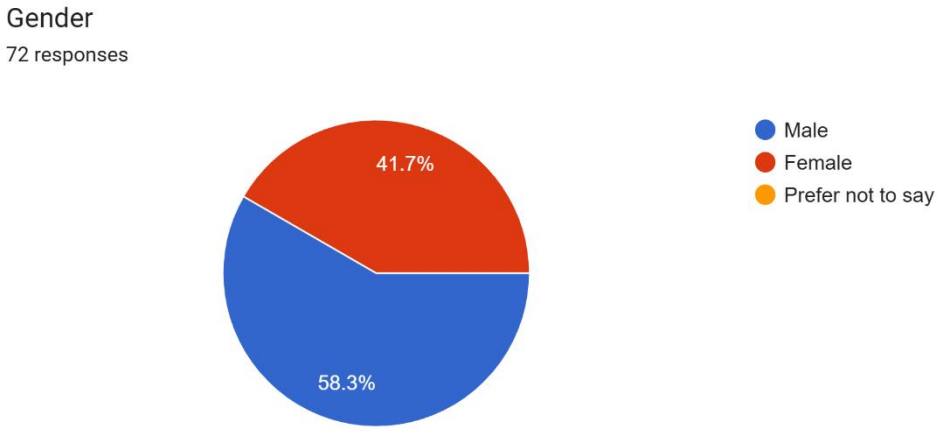
DATA ANALYSIS

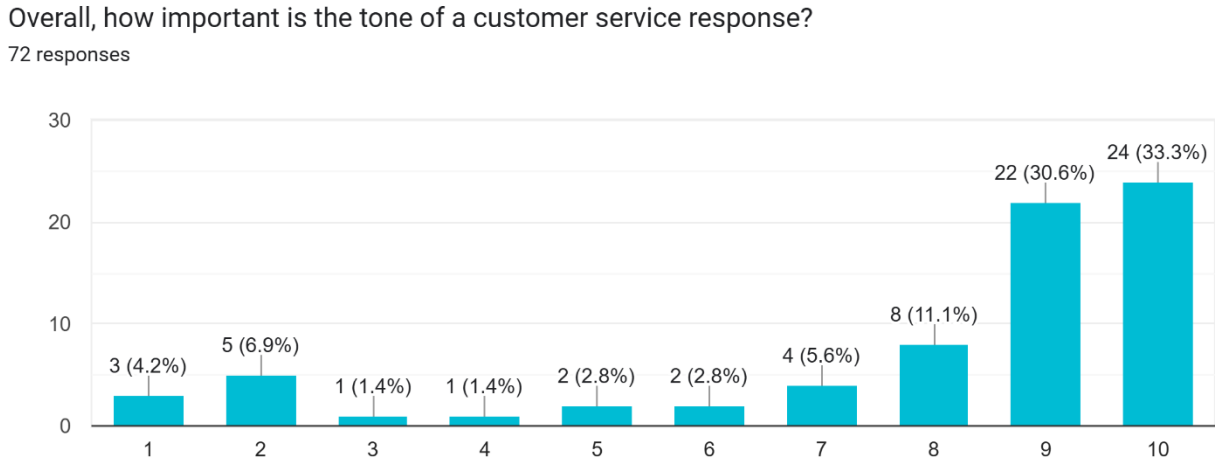
- The chart shows that most respondents (62.5%) belong to the 18–22 age group, followed by 27.7% in the 23–26 age group. A smaller proportion of respondents fall under the other age categories. This indicates that the survey data is largely representative of younger individuals who frequently interact with digital customer service platforms.



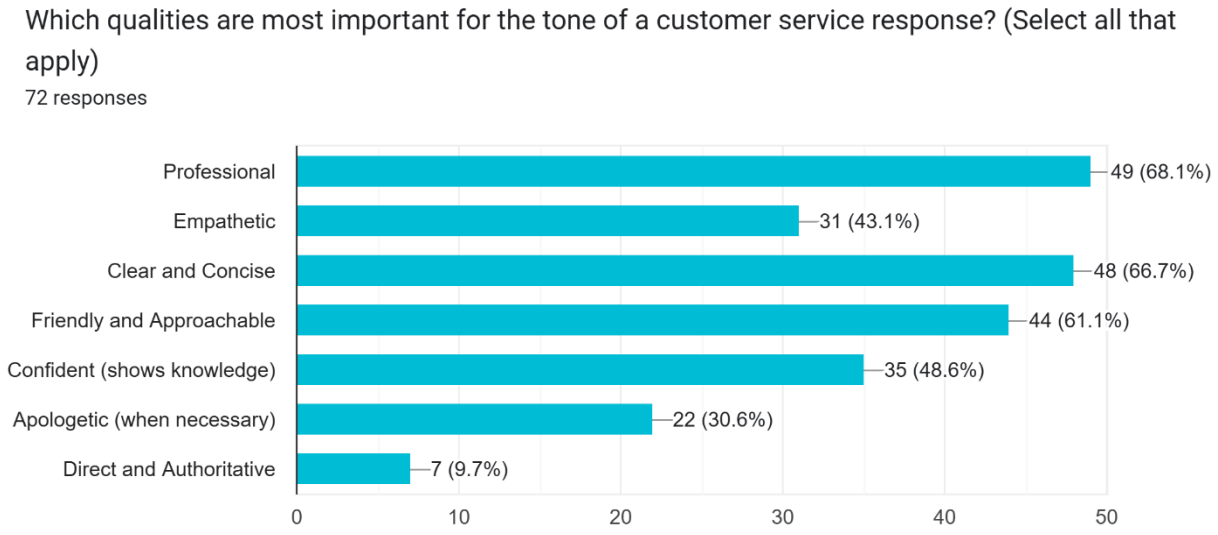
- The chart indicates that 58.3% of the respondents are male, while 41.7% are female. This reflects a balanced gender distribution among the participants, providing diverse perspectives on tone in customer service communication.



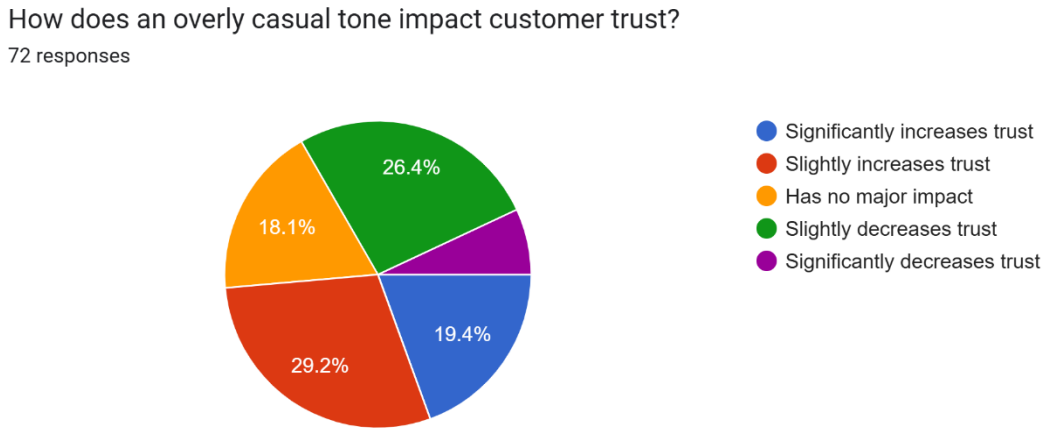
- The chart illustrates respondents' perceptions of the importance of tone in customer service responses on a scale of 1 to 10. Most respondents rated the importance highly, with 63.9% assigning scores of 9 or 10. Very few respondents rated tone as unimportant, indicating a strong consensus that tone plays a critical role in shaping customer service experiences.



- The chart indicates that respondents consider professionalism (68.1%) and clarity and conciseness (66.7%) as the most important qualities in customer service responses. This is followed by friendliness and approachability (61.1%) and confidence in knowledge (48.6%). Empathy (43.1%) and an apologetic tone when necessary (30.6%) are also valued, while a direct and authoritative tone (9.7%) is considered least important. These findings suggest that customers prefer responses that are professional, clear, and approachable rather than overly authoritative.



- The chart shows mixed perceptions regarding the impact of an overly casual tone on customer trust. While 48.6% of respondents indicated that a casual tone increases trust to some extent, 26.4% reported a slight decrease in trust, and a smaller proportion indicated a significant decrease. Additionally, 18.1% felt that an overly casual tone has no major impact. These findings suggest that while casual tone may be positively received by some customers, it also carries the risk of reducing trust, indicating the need for careful tone moderation.



- The chart indicates that respondents largely view humor as appropriate only in limited situations. 34.7% believe humor should be used only if the customer initiates a humorous tone, while 33.3% feel it is suitable only in minor, non-critical issues. In contrast, 15.3% consider humor never appropriate, and only a small proportion support frequent or unconditional use of humor. These results suggest that humor should be applied cautiously and contextually in written customer service communication.

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RESULTS AND INTERPRETATION

The results of the study clearly indicate that tone plays a critical role in written customer service communication. A strong majority of respondents rated the importance of tone at the higher end of the scale, demonstrating that customers place significant value on how service responses are framed, not just on the resolution provided. This highlights tone as a key determinant of customer satisfaction and overall service experience.

The demographic analysis shows that the survey responses are largely influenced by younger respondents who are frequent users of digital customer service platforms. The relatively balanced gender distribution suggests that perceptions regarding tone are not heavily skewed by gender and can be considered broadly representative within the sample.

The findings further reveal that respondents strongly prefer customer service responses that are professional, clear, concise, and friendly, indicating that customers seek a balance between emotional sensitivity and informational clarity. While empathy is valued, excessive emotionality or informality is not universally preferred. This suggests that customers expect customer service communication to remain composed and respectful, even when addressing complaints.

The results also indicate mixed perceptions regarding the use of an overly casual tone. Although some respondents perceive casual tone as trust-enhancing, a considerable proportion associate it with reduced trust or no significant impact. This highlights the potential risk of adopting overly informal communication styles, particularly in situations involving service failures or critical issues.

Additionally, the findings show that humor is generally perceived as appropriate only in specific and limited contexts, such as minor issues or when initiated by the customer. The low acceptance of frequent or unconditional humor suggests that customers may interpret humor as unprofessional or dismissive in serious service situations.

Overall, the interpretation of results suggests that there is no universally effective tone for all customer service interactions. Instead, tone effectiveness is context-dependent and must be aligned with the nature of the issue, customer expectations, and communication channel.

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FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

Findings

- The study finds that the tone of written customer service responses is perceived as highly important by most respondents, indicating that customers place strong emphasis on how service communication is framed.
- Most respondents prefer customer service responses that are professional, clear, and concise, suggesting that clarity and professionalism are fundamental expectations in written service communication.
- Empathy and friendliness are identified as important tonal qualities; however, respondents do not favour overly emotional or excessively informal communication styles.
- An overly casual tone is found to have mixed effects on customer trust, with a significant proportion of respondents indicating a decrease in trust when the tone becomes too informal.
- The use of humor in written customer service responses is generally viewed as appropriate only in limited contexts, such as minor issues or when initiated by the customer.
- Younger respondents, who form most of the sample, show heightened sensitivity toward tone, reflecting their frequent engagement with digital customer service platforms.

Discussion

The findings of this study are consistent with existing literature that emphasizes the importance of tone in customer service communication. Prior research by Yin et al. (2017) and Hu et al. (2018) highlights that tone acts as a substitute for non-verbal cues in digital interactions, significantly influencing customer satisfaction and emotional response. The strong emphasis placed on tone by respondents in this study reinforces these findings and underscores the strategic role of tone in written service communication.

The preference for professional, clear, and concise responses aligns with the work of Prasad (2020), which suggests that clarity and professionalism enhance perceived service quality and organizational credibility. While empathy is valued, the findings indicate that excessive emotionality or informality may be perceived as unprofessional, supporting De Keyzer et al.'s (2017) argument that emotional tone effectiveness is context-dependent.

The mixed perceptions regarding overly casual tone support the conclusions drawn by Barcelos et al. (2017), who found that conversational tones can enhance engagement in certain contexts but may reduce trust in service recovery or high-risk situations. This suggests that organizations must carefully balance warmth and professionalism to avoid negative customer perceptions.

The limited acceptance of humor in customer service responses further aligns with crisis communication research, which cautions against the use of humor in sensitive or complaint-driven interactions. Respondents' preference for humor only in minor or customer-initiated contexts supports Stewart's (2025) findings that humor may undermine credibility during service failures.

Overall, the discussion highlights that tone effectiveness is highly situational and influenced by customer expectations, issue severity, and communication context. These findings emphasize the need for tone-aware customer service strategies that adapt communication style based on situational cues rather than relying on standardized response templates.

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CONCLUSION

The objective of this study was to examine the role of tone in writing customer service responses and to understand how different tonal approaches influence customer satisfaction, trust, and service recovery outcomes. In an increasingly digital service environment, where customer interactions are largely mediated through written communication, tone has emerged as a critical element of effective corporate communication. The findings of this research clearly indicate that customers do not evaluate service responses based solely on the accuracy or speed of resolution, but also on the emotional and attitudinal cues conveyed through tone.

The study reveals that respondents strongly perceive tone as an essential component of customer service communication. Professionalism, clarity, and friendliness were identified as the most preferred tonal qualities, suggesting that customers expect responses that are respectful, composed, and easy to understand. While empathy is valued, the findings indicate that customers prefer a balanced tone that acknowledges their concerns without appearing overly emotional or informal.

The research further demonstrates that overly casual or humorous tones can negatively impact customer trust, particularly in situations involving service failures or complaints. Although humor and casual language may enhance rapport in limited and non-critical contexts, their indiscriminate use poses a risk to perceived professionalism and credibility.

From an academic perspective, this study contributes to the growing body of literature on corporate communication and service recovery by integrating primary data with established theoretical insights. From a managerial standpoint, the results underscore the need for organizations to move beyond standardized response templates and adopt tone-aware communication strategies. The study concludes that effective tone management is not merely a soft skill but a strategic necessity for organizations seeking to enhance customer satisfaction, build trust, and maintain a positive brand image. Future research may expand this study by examining tone effectiveness across different industries, cultural contexts, and AI-driven communication platforms.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on the findings of the study, several practical recommendations are proposed for organizations aiming to improve the effectiveness of their written customer service communication. First, organizations should develop tone-specific communication guidelines that clearly outline appropriate tonal approaches for different service situations. These guidelines should distinguish between responses to routine inquiries, complaints, and service failures, ensuring that customer service representatives adopt tones that are both empathetic and professional.

Second, customer service training programs should place greater emphasis on tone management and emotional intelligence. Employees should be trained to recognize customer emotions and adapt their tone accordingly, rather than relying on rigid scripts. Role-based training and scenario simulations can help representatives practice responding to customers with appropriate tone while maintaining clarity and consistency.

Third, organizations should adopt a balanced tone framework that integrates professionalism, clarity, and warmth. Overly casual or humorous language should be used sparingly and only in contexts where it is clearly appropriate, such as minor issues or when initiated by the customer. In complaint-handling and service recovery situations, organizations should prioritize respectful, empathetic, and solution-oriented tones to rebuild trust.

Finally, organizations should regularly collect customer feedback specifically related to communication tone. Incorporating tone-related metrics into customer satisfaction surveys can provide valuable insights for continuous improvement. By treating tone as a measurable and manageable aspect of customer service, organizations can enhance customer relationships, strengthen brand credibility, and achieve sustainable service excellence.

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